on that score, the pressures and responses coming in the wake of the Ukraine conflict have set it to rest.

But also reflect for a moment how much the big issues of our times, pandemic, terrorism and climate change, impact your very existence. Ask yourself whether we should not have a greater say in the search for solutions. It also matters to all of us what other nations think of India, our culture and our way of life. After all, the G20 presidency offers a unique chance to make the world more conversant with India and our own people more ready to explore opportunities abroad. Should we not then shape our image and influence the narrative? At the same time, the challenge is to do so without opening a way for external forces to interfere in our national debates and development. These are but a sample of how, in an increasingly connected world, the attitude, perceptions and interests of others are so relevant. If they have to be managed and leveraged, then it is all the more necessary for a sharper realization at home that foreign policy really matters.

DIPLOMACY AND NATIONAL SECURITY

For all societies, security ranks foremost in their priorities. The reason is obvious: it affects the very nature of our collective. This has a territorial aspect as well as that of safety, law and order and well-being. They are often connected because together, they determine the national spirit and existence. India faces more than its fair share of external challenges, in part because many of our boundaries have not been fully settled. The resulting contestations are obviously a call on both determination and resources. We saw that earlier with Pakistan and more recently with China. But they demand equally that energies be focussed on ensuring optimal positions, on the ground as much as in negotiations. Given the serious repercussions of such differences, it is also very relevant to ensuring peace and tranquillity, if not more.

Diplomacy is a natural partner of defence. Most of the time, it is the first line; on occasion, it is also the back-up. After all, most military situations do end up at the conference table! Indeed, the achievements of foreign policy in stabilizing the neighbourhood are very much the basis for progress and development at home.